Taiwan - Holiday Lore

JB

Legend - Chinese

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"This is a story about a cowherd and a weaver girl. Originally, the two did not know each other, and were very efficient workers. The boy herded cows well, and the girl wove nice cloth; both did very good work. One day, they met, and fell in love. Soon, they were always playing together and neglecting their work. This made the gods very angry because they forgot about their responsibilities. The gods decided to punish them and cast them away to opposite sides of the Milky Way. Although the gods were angry, they pitied the young lovers and allowed them to meet once a year. When the sparrows lined up along the sky to form a bridge, on July 7 of every [lunar calendar] year, the lovers would be able to meet. This day is called "chi shi ( )" in Chinese; it means "night of seven." And this is the origin of Chinese Valentine's Day, which is on July 7th of the lunar calendar."

Linda Wei was born in Pingtung, Taiwan. She grew up in a big family with many older people, including her parents, her grandmother, and another aunt. She believes she learned this story when she was around 10 years old, either from one of these older women or from a teacher at school. This is a very famous story, according to the informant. It is supposed to be inspirational for young lovers, and also to teach them not to neglect their responsibilities. When I asked her why the holiday was in July, she replied that she did not know. Like many holidays in the Chinese Lunar Calendar, this lovers' holiday has the same number for the month and the

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day, as in the seventh day of the seventh month. The informant thinks that this makes the holiday easier to remember. She adds that no one says "July 7th" for the holiday, only "chi shi."

Every year around this date, young lovers celebrate their love for each other with gifts and romance. It is in fact very similar to Valentine's Day. At first when I heard this story, I struggled between characterizing it as a myth or a legend, because it explains the origin of a date and includes divine intervention. However, it does take place after the creation of man and the world. Also, Chinese people take this to be a true story. They believe that the couple existed, and that it is because of them that we have Chi Shi.